

World Bank Socio-Economic Indicators from 2000 to 2023: A Comparative Analysis of South Africa and Its Immediate Neighbors.

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Executive Summary

This data analysis project compares South Africa with its six neighboring countries. These countries are Mozambique, Botswana, Eswatini, Zimbabwe, Namibia, and Lesotho. The comparative analysis examines development gaps between South Africa and its neighboring countries using World Bank Socio-Economic Indicators from 2000 to 2023, with a particular focus on 2023. This analysis aims to identify disparities in economic and social performance and to provide data-driven recommendations to promote balanced regional development and reduce immigration pressure driven by differences in social and economic opportunities.

One of the most significant insights is that a high GDP does not necessarily translate into a high GDP per capita. South Africa is the leader in terms of GDP but ranks second to Botswana in GDP per capita. Another insight I gained from the analysis is that a high GDP does not necessarily mean a low unemployment rate. South Africa in 2023 had the second-highest unemployment rate of 32.1%, after Eswatini, with 34.61%.

Raw data for this project was obtained from Kaggle. Microsoft Excel was used to clean and organize the data, and SQL was used to perform cleaning, run queries, and analyze the data. Finally, Microsoft Power BI was used for visualization and to create charts.

Introduction

Governments across the world need vital tools to evaluate development and identify inequalities in their countries to plan and execute growth strategies. These tools can be referred to as socio-economic indicators. According to ScienceDirect (2026), Socio-Economic Indicators can be defined as data measures employed to evaluate the economic and social performance of a country. They include factors such as the standard of living, Gross Domestic Product, Income, health, education, and literacy rate, etc.

The dataset was acquired from Kaggle and included 22 socioeconomic indicators for 217 countries in the world, but the focus of this project was on South Africa and its immediate neighboring countries. The

primary goal was to analyze development gaps in the region and recommend strategies to address them. The lack of social and economic benefits for residents leads to high volumes of migration, as people from countries with fewer economic and social opportunities migrate to countries with stronger economies in an attempt to seize opportunities. However, this creates problems for the natives of those countries, as opportunities become scarce, leading to unemployment and pressure on certain departments, such as health, with public hospitals lacking enough beds and medication. Therefore, balanced development in the region is necessary, as it would address many of the development problems.

The countries involved in the analysis project are South Africa, Lesotho, Eswatini, Botswana, Namibia, Mozambique, and Zimbabwe, which are South Africa's immediate neighboring countries.

The socio-economic Indicators in the analysis are categorized into three, with 8 indicators in total, and a category including all seven countries, their unique country IDs, and demographics such as capital city, income level, and longitude & latitude positions, which this analysis will not focus much on. In total, the categories are: Countries, GDP, Technology, and Population & Health.

Data Description

Raw data was acquired from Kaggle, and the dataset is about Socio-economic indicators from 2000 to 2023 according to the World Bank. The countries involved in the analysis are South Africa, Lesotho, Eswatini, Botswana, Namibia, Mozambique, and Zimbabwe.

The four categories were customized for this project. The first category is 'Countries', which includes all seven countries and their unique country IDs, income levels, capital cities, and longitude and latitude. The other three categories are: GDP, Technology, and Population & Health. GDP contains the following indicators: GDP, GDP per capita, GDP growth, and unemployment rate. Technology contains internet users. Population & Health contains the following indicators: total population, life expectancy, and health expenditure.

There were some limitations; for instance, some of the data was missing for certain variables or indicators for certain countries in specific years. For instance, in 2023, there was no data collected for Botswana's Internet users, which resulted in NULLS when doing analysis in SQL.

Data Cleaning and Preparation

Microsoft Excel was used to filter the countries to focus on the seven included in this analysis, since the original file contained socio-economic indicators for 217 countries in the world. After the filtering of countries, duplicates were removed, spelling errors corrected, and unnecessary spaces addressed. Numbers were then formatted where there were numerical figures and kept general where there was text, so that the files could run smoothly in SQL when doing data analysis. Columns were made visible and clear, using the same font, font size, and font type. This ensured consistency across all categories. After the data cleaning process in Excel, the four categories, namely: countries, GDP, Technology, and Population & health, were exported into separate CSV files to later import into SQL for analysis.

The analyst realized that he had overlooked a typing error for the capital city of Botswana, as he was to start with the analysis but had to update the table to correct the unnoticed mistake in Excel during the data cleaning process. The UPDATE statement in SQL was used as follows:

```
UPDATE world_bank_socioeconomic_indicators.countries
```

```
SET capital_city = 'Gaborone'
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```
WHERE country_name = 'Botswana';
```

The query updated the table and fixed the spelling error, and then I was able to start analyzing the data.

Methodology

This project employed a quantitative approach to analyze and compare socioeconomic indicators for South Africa and its immediate neighboring countries from 2000 to 2023, by the World Bank on Kaggle. Secondary was the only type of data that was consulted, in the form of the dataset itself, and reliable websites for definitions and extra information about the countries involved in the analysis. Sites such as SADC, Hellen Suzman Foundation, ScienceDirect, etc., were used to acquire external data to make the analysis, discussion of insights, and recommendations possible. The key variables in the analysis contain GDP, GDP per Capita, GDP growth, Unemployment rate, population, life expectancy, health expenditure, and internet usage.

Data was prepared in Microsoft Excel, where structuring, filtering, formatting, and data cleaning transpired. SQL was then employed for minor data cleaning before analysis could take place. The analyst had not noticed the spelling error during the data cleaning process in Excel for the spelling of the capital

city of Botswana and therefore had to update the 'countries' table in SQL to rectify the mistake using the UPDATE statement in SQL.

The whole data analysis was done in SQL, and key operations included:

- Using an **INNER JOIN** to retrieve data from the Countries and GDP to see the top three GDPs amongst the countries in the maximum (**MAX**) GDP year, being the most recent year, which is 2023.
- Calculating GDP per Capita by dividing: GDP/Population total and using an alias for clarity (**AS gdp_per_capita**). Secondly, used two **INNER JOINS** between population & Health and GDP, and GDP and countries, to retrieve Countries with the best GDP per Capita using the **MAX** GDP year, 2023.
- Retrieving the fastest economies in the region by finding the average GDP growth (**AVG** (GDP_growth_usd_pct)) **BETWEEN** year 2000 **AND** 2023, and using an alias for clarity (**AS Average_growth**). Secondly, used an **INNER JOIN** for GDP and countries to retrieve the fastest GDP growth in the region and **GROUP BY** countries, in descending order (**ORDER BY Average_growth DESC**).
- Compared GDP and Unemployment, using an **INNER JOIN** between GDP and Countries in the **MAX** GDP year, which is 2023.
- Compared GDP and socio-economic developments, where Country name, GDP, Population, Life expectancy, and Health expenditure were retrieved using **INNER JOINS** between GDP and Population Health, and GDP and Countries in the **MAX** GDP year, which is 2023.
- Compared Internet development within the region, using a **LEFT JOIN** between Countries and Technology to retrieve countries' internet users in the **MAX** Technology year, which is 2023.
- To see key insights on GDP, GDP growth, and Internet users in the **MAX** GDP year, using **LEFT JOINS** between GDP and Technology, and GDP and Countries.

The common SQL operators used to retrieve data include **SELECT, FROM, WHERE, BETWEEN, AND, INNER JOIN, LEFT JOIN, ON, AS, GROUP BY, ORDER BY, DESC, ASC, and LIMIT**.

After the analysis, the tables were exported to Microsoft Power BI for visualization. Charts were created to clearly communicate insights, such as trends, comparisons, and findings, thereby enabling interpretation and informed decision-making.

Data Analysis

1. Top 3 Economies (GDP in USD) by Country in the latest year (2023).

South Africa is the largest economy in the region, with a GDP of approximately \$381.4 billion, followed by Zimbabwe with \$35.9 billion and Mozambique with \$20.9 billion. This alone shows South Africa's dominance in GDP in the region, although the gap remains substantial.

2. GDP per Capita (GDP in USD) by Country in the latest year (2023).

Unlike total GDP, Botswana is leading in GDP per Capita at approximately \$7,826, followed by South Africa at \$6,034 and Namibia at \$4,187, while Lesotho and Mozambique have the lowest GDP per Capita of less than \$1000. This indicates that having a high GDP doesn't translate to a high individual income level, as Botswana outperformed South Africa regarding GDP per Capita.

3. Economic Growth from 2000 to 2023.

The fastest-growing economy in the region over the period is Mozambique, with a growth percentage of 5.96, followed by Botswana at 3.44% and Namibia at 3.36%. South Africa ranks 5th with a growth rate of 2.29%, portraying a slower long-term expansion. This suggests that the gap in GDP compels smaller economies in the region to grow their economies to catch up with South Africa as a bigger economy.

4. The Relationship between GDP and Unemployment rate in the latest year (2023).

A higher GDP doesn't necessarily mean low unemployment; South Africa is an example. It leads the region in GDP but has the second-highest unemployment rate of 32.1%, following Eswatini, which has the highest unemployment rate of 34.61%. In contrast, countries that appear to have lower GDP in the region have lower unemployment rates, such as Mozambique at 6.66% and Zimbabwe at 9.35%.

This shows that higher GDP doesn't translate to a lower unemployment rate, and it means that the government of South Africa is inefficient in creating enough jobs for its people.

5. GDP and Socio-economic Development Indicators in the latest year (2023).

High spending on health doesn't translate to high life expectancy. Lesotho is the highest spender as far as health is concerned, at 12.61% going into health; however, it has the lowest life expectancy of 57 years. In contrast, Botswana spent only 6.26% on health but has the highest life expectancy of 69 years, followed by South Africa, which spends a slightly higher percentage on health, compared to Botswana, of 8.91%, and has the second highest life expectancy of 66 years.

6. Internet Development in the latest year (2023).

South Africa is leading in internet access, with 78.34% of its population having access to the internet, followed by Namibia at 63.7% and Eswatini at 61.33%. The country with the lowest level of internet access in the region is Mozambique at 19.95%. The gap between the country with the highest internet access and that with the lowest access is significantly high, at 58.39%. This digital divide needs to be addressed as the internet is of great significance in this digital era for any economy in the world.

7. Key Insights and Relationships in the latest year (2023).

- South Africa is a leader in GDP, but not in GDP per Capita; Botswana is.
- The fastest-growing economies in the region, like Mozambique at 5.48%, are small compared to South Africa, a big economy, but with a GDP growth rate of merely 0.81% in 2023.
- A high GDP doesn't translate to unemployment; it does not mean a guarantee of jobs.
- Social outcomes don't depend on spending greater portions of the economy on health, but rather on efficiency.
- Having high internet access doesn't mean fast economic growth, since countries with the highest economic growth, like Mozambique, have the lowest internet access.

Discussion of Insights

The findings of this analysis suggest that socio-economic development depends on several interconnected factors, such as employment creation, economic growth, and healthcare efficiency, among others. For instance, South Africa is the largest economy in the region, a result of the country's performance across multiple sectors, including manufacturing, agriculture, mining, and tourism. Despite its GDP dominance, the standard of living of its citizens is not on par with that of Botswana, as Botswana leads in GDP per capita in the region as of 2023, followed by South Africa.

Having GDP dominance does not imply fast GDP growth. According to the World Bank findings, small economies such as Mozambique have faster growth in the region than mature economies such as South Africa. This is a result of a diversified economic base, which is contributing to this growth as these countries focus on sectors such as tourism, transport, agriculture, and communications, rather than focusing on a single sector, such as mining. South Africa's slow GDP growth (the slowest in the region in

2023) is a contributing factor to the high unemployment rate of 0.81% in 2023. The slow growth is only technical, driven by improvements in investor confidence and power generation; however, it does not translate into economic relief for citizens, resulting in a high unemployment rate.

The findings further show that high expenditure on health doesn't necessarily translate to better social outcomes; for instance, Lesotho spends 12.61% of its GDP on health, making it the highest in the region; however, it has the lowest life expectancy of 57 years as of 2023. Its major health problems stem from its high HIV/AIDS prevalence (Ranked the 3rd highest HIV/AIDS country in the World in 2023), with a low number of Nurses and Doctors per Capita. According to a study, there are approximately 0.9 doctors per 10,000 Basotho, meaning that the health department in the country is under-resourced, which makes it hard for many of its residents to receive medical attention, therefore contributing to the low life expectancy rate.

People in countries with low GDP per capita, like Mozambique (\$ 622) and Lesotho (\$ 916.28), are most likely to migrate to countries with stronger economies, such as South Africa. This means that South Africans would have to share the few employment opportunities, public services such as free healthcare for all people in the country, and infrastructure. Therefore, balanced economic growth in the region is necessary to address these inequalities and improve long-term regional sustainability.

We are living in a digital era, and therefore, access to mobile devices and the internet is important. However, economic growth can be achieved even when internet usage is low. For instance, Mozambique has the lowest internet penetration in the region at 19.95%, but it is the fastest-growing economy, with a growth rate of 5.48% in 2023. On the contrary, South Africa has the highest number of internet users among its population at 78.34% in 2023, but attained the lowest GDP growth of 0.81% in 2023, making it the lowest GDP growth in the region.

Mozambique's fast growth is attributed to its diversified economic base, focusing on various sectors of the economy, such as tourism, natural resources, and policy implementation to encourage the private sector to be part of the economy, and investment in the country's economy. Mozambique's integration into SADC is another factor contributing to its fast GDP growth. This enables the country to have access to a broader market, where it can trade with other countries within the region and Africa as a whole.

Recommendations

There is a need for policy creation in all the countries in the region for socio-economic development to manifest. It doesn't help for a country to have economic growth that does not effectively translate into economic benefits for the ordinary citizens, such as job opportunities; therefore, there needs to be policies centered around employment creation, especially in sectors that have high employment potential, such as agriculture, technology, manufacturing, and small business development.

Countries with slow GDP growth should implement robust strategies to encourage private-sector participation in the economy, infrastructure development, and trade within the region and continent. If the region can achieve balanced development, the issue of people migrating to countries with stronger economies for economic and social opportunities would be resolved, as stronger economic growth would improve the standard of living and reduce development disparities. Regional cooperation should be strengthened to achieve balanced regional development, for instance, through infrastructure development, trade, and economic partnerships.

The analysis indicates that high health expenditure doesn't translate to better health outcomes. What's important is efficiency, accessibility, and the quality of healthcare services. For instance, Lesotho should invest in education programs to produce more doctors and nurses, since there is a shortage of both per Capita. This would improve accessibility and quality, as more people will have access to healthcare services, and there would be adequate medical staff to handle all health-related problems in the country.

Since we are living in a digital era, the entire region must invest more in digital infrastructure. Digital access and the internet can encourage education, communication, innovation, and participation in the digital economy, curbing unemployment.

Speaking of unemployment, one of the major contributing factors to this problem is the lack of proper education, digital literacy, and the right skills. It is therefore upon governments to invest in education and skills development in accordance with the shortage of certain skills in the economy, thereby curbing unemployment and growing the economy.

Conclusion

The findings of this analysis suggest that socio-economic disparities exist in the region and that a balanced development approach is needed to solve social and economic problems. South Africa has the largest GDP in the region, but has the slowest GDP growth, and as a result, has one of the highest unemployment rates in the world. The government needs to invest in the right education, skills, and training in fields that have high potential in employment creation.

Throughout the analysis, it appears that there is still a need for growth regarding digital infrastructure and internet access, with South Africa leading in internet access at 78.34%, and Mozambique having the lowest access of 19.95%. This signals the importance of investing in digital infrastructure and internet access and capitalizing on the digital economy. In doing so, employment will be created, and GDP per Capita will improve.

The GDP gap between South Africa and its neighbors is substantial, which shows the need for countries to diversify their economic base by finding other means of generating income and not focus solely on traditional sectors of the economy, such as mining, but should invest in others, such as arts, culture, tourism, and events.

Overall, the analysis shows the need to strengthen regional collaboration beyond what is currently there. If countries could invest in building infrastructure, such as national roads for easy regional trade, and hospitals for easy access to health care, etc. Economic partnership would also encourage balanced regional development, such as developing one currency and backing it with our mineral resources. It would make the currency stronger versus the United States Dollar, thereby enabling social and economic development and addressing development gaps in the region.

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